



A Journey, Not A Destination

What We Love
Its art direction and humour
Its dialogues and voice acting
Its fun combat system
and its cool dungeons
Roleplaying (expressions, relationships, jobs, economy)
The dog and how it replaces the HUD
The breadcrumb trail that points to where you ought to be
Relationships, and owning property

What We Hate
The world is not very open-ended
Combat is not very tactical
Shallow roleplaying and morality
No real penalties
Ho-hum villain
Dog fails to create a strong emotional bond
No proper map

**"Do you like sex?
The physical act of
love. Coitus.
Do you like it?"**

It has been a really, really, long day. I just fought these magic-dudes force-pushing me around; opening me up for their henchmen. Must have been 50 of them.

The swamps are infested with the rotting undead and the banshee-mothers have knife-wielding tots on their knees. Hack hack hack, some fancy shooting and fireballs, thrown in for style.

Then behold.. town of pirates and whores – not one filthy soul so much as waves at me. This really, really hurts. This needs fixing of course. They must love me. All of them. Vital.

The first thing to do though is to make the best of the town's destitution. Shopping, not for clothes but shops and houses – cheap as they are.

Buy the stone-cutter's shop, the blacksmith's and the town's watering hole. The salon's called Curl Up and Dye – I want. The more I buy, the more I earn.

Now to impressing the locals. A head for a trophy works. So does playing the lute for the chicks. Let's top this off with a nice long fart. Ah yes, everybody loves me.

"Do you like sex? The physical act of love. Coitus. Do you like it?" asks one in a rather

revealing outfit. Do I ever... Thumbs up. This town could use a bastard spawn of mine.

Ego Massage

Fable 2 constantly rubs you the right way. It adores and worships you, as this world needs saving. It also forgives you. For instance bigamy is an achievement. Just don't let the two (or more) near each other, or you might need to kill one. Go on a villainous rampage and get the respect of shopkeepers. How about a discount? Bloody nice. Go on to force the town's economy to collapse by looting and murdering? The resultant real-estate market

crash, allows you to pick the best houses at a killing. And if you would ever want to change your wicked ways, then you could offer large donations to the local temple, to literally wash away your sins. Ain't religion grand?! So relax, and just enjoy yourself.

In many ways, the game is like your companion dog. It doesn't care which way your morality falls. It loves you – tail wagging – and just wants to play fetch...

Playing Fetch

If a good ego massage doesn't do it for you, then the game's humour, combat and art direction will.

The amount of love and detail put into creating *Fable 2* shines forth and constantly keeps you amused. Like when you hear your companion quip when he meets the aforementioned constantly-chattering blind hag: "...blind eh? I would've preferred mute". The game is self-aware and will constantly poke fun at itself, venting potential frustration through humour.

Falling Short

The game will never frustrate you; even death can literally be brushed off for the price of a scar or two. And therein lies its biggest fault – the game's a little bit

shallow. Farting as a means of making amends with your beleaguered wife only goes so far, before falling flat. So does the combat – as fun as it is, it's not very strategic, and thus not very satisfying. The world is more open-ended than *Fable 1* but it's not quite enough. The game's morality – the fulcrum upon which the entire game moves – is easily fooled: kill everyone, and then throw in cash to be forgiven. Eat meat to gain weight and lose purity, and then binge on celery to lose it as quickly.

But even while you are abusing its very forgiving systems, it will keep you entertained. It never

bore, never punishes, never judges (except for when the children tease you when you dress in a frock). *Fable 2* is a fairy-tale casting you as the prince or princess, charming or otherwise.

Ultimately though, you should play it – because it's the most unique, fresh, innovative, enjoyable game you will have ever played. Heck, any game that quotes from *The Big Lebowski* is A-OK in my book. Peter and his team can sell me a bridge anytime.

Developer: 7/10
Developer: GSC Game World
Web site: Deep Silver